

“To send light into the depths of the human heart—this is the artist’s calling.”

ROBERT SCHUMANN

Building a career

The Abegg Variations, published as his Opus 1 in 1831, was the first of a series of remarkable works for solo piano that expressed his complex mind and strikingly original musical sensibility, from Papillons (1832) and Carnaval (1835) to the Davidsbündlertänze (1837) and Kreisleriana (1838). Free in form, innovative in harmony, and often literary in inspiration, these suites expressed a wide range of mercurial moods, while also abounding in personal references and musical cryptograms (see [box](#)). In this same period, Schumann established himself as a leading music journalist, and founded the influential New Journal for Music in 1834. In his writings, he invented contrasting personae to represent opposed sides of his personality—the virile and assertive Florestan and the dreamy, reflective Eusebius.